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A ‘Historical Adjustment’

If there is an apology, what will it achieve? It is a question worth posing because when it comes to the Jallianwala Bagh Massacre in 1919, even at the time, Winston Churchill, the secretary of state for war, denounced General Dyer’s actions as ‘an extraordinary event, a monstrous event, an event which stands in singular and sinister isolation’.[1] It is debatable whether this was indeed a barbarity of ‘singular and sinister isolation’ in the history of the British Empire. It appears not. Nevertheless, the value and practical utility of an apology today from a global power that is no longer in the ascendancy but very much in decline is not a matter of insignificance, which can be ignored. It needs to be taken into account in the face of ever more strident calls for an apology, because as Patrick Cockburn has argued, ‘[f]uture historians may well pick 2019 as a decisive year in the decline of the US and UK as world powers’ and that ‘[t]his geopolitical shift comes exactly a century after the Treaty of Versailles, in 1919, when the US and UK were at the peak of their power in determining the fate of nations after the First World War’. He points out that ‘[l]ike most political retreats, the present one by the US and UK is masked by patriotic bombast about “Making America Great Again” or launching a post-Brexit “Global Britain” but the reality will soon be all too clear when the mask eventually falls’. For him, the British 2019 general election is the ‘election that will be the point of no return for Britain in the current phase of its decline’. He has no doubt that in the pursuit of ‘Brexit as an act of self-destructive folly’, what is now inevitable is that ‘the country will be without real allies for the first time for over 200 years – historians say the last such moment was during some particularly dire moment during the Napoleonic wars’.[2]